

We must next define the text—precisely what profile are we looking for; how can we know if a MS is ‘perfect’? This question lands us squarely in the snake pit of NT textual criticism [and most of the snakes are poisonous]. What I think on that subject began to appear in print in 1977¹ and I will not repeat here what is available elsewhere. As a tactical withdrawal I will retreat to an easier question (but I will return to the main one): How can we know if a MS is a perfect representative of its text-type, that is, of its family archetype? To gain time I will illustrate the theory with a concrete example. I invite attention to the chart that follows:

Performance of f³⁵ MSS in Individual Books for the General Epistles²

Key:

- s = singular reading (until all MSS have been collated, this is just an assumption);
c = corrected variant (variation of any kind corrected to the presumed archetype);
x = uncorrected variant (‘variant’ here means that it is attested by MSS outside the family);
/ = family is divided (a splinter group);
h = an obvious case of homoioteleuton (or –arcton), involving a line or more;
i = sheer inattention (usually repeating a syllable from one line to the next);
--- = no departures from the presumed profile.

MS	James	1 Peter	2 Peter	1 John	2 John	3 John	Jude	date	location	corpus exemplar
18	---	1x,2/	1s	1x,2/	---	1s	---	1364	Constantinople	2x,4/
35	2c	2c	---	2c	---	---	2c	XI	Aegean	---
141	1/,2s	1x,4/, 2s	1c,1s	1/,3s, 2h	---	---	---	XIII	Vatican	1x,6/
149	1x,5/, 1c,7s	1x,8/, 3s	5/,2s	4/,1c, 3s	---	1/	1/,1c	XV	Vatican	2x,24/
201	5/,1s	7/	3/	2/	---	1/	1/	1357	London	19/
204	1x	1/	2/,2s	---	---	---	---	XIII	Bologna	1x,3/
328	1x,5/, 2s	5/,4s	1x,2/, 1s	2x,4/, 1c,1s	---	---	1x, 1s	XIII	Leiden	5x,16/
386	2/	1/,1s	1/,2s	3/,3s, 1h	---	---	---	XIV	Vatican	7/
394	2/	4/,1c, 1i	4/	4/,1s	---	1i	---	1330	Rome	14/
432	5/,3s, 1h	10/,6s	1x,2/, 1c,1s	1x,5/, 1c,1s, 1h	2s	1/	3s	XV	Vatican	2x,23/
604	6/,1s	1x,11/, 1s	4/,1c, 1s	7/,1s	1x	1/	---	XIV	Paris	2x,29/
664 ³	4x,5/, 21s	5x,9/, 1c,25s	4/,1c, 14s	6x,6/, 14s,1h	1x,1s	3s	3s	XV	Zittau	16x,24

¹ *The Identity of the New Testament Text* (Nashville: Thomas Nelson Inc., Publishers, 1977)—but now please see the present edition, *The Identity of the New Testament Text IV*.

² I collated all forty-three of these manuscripts myself.

³ For all its wildness, 664 has all the diagnostic f³⁵ readings, and thus is clearly a family member (albeit sloppy and promiscuous).